

Phrasing

If you are setting lyrics to music, they will determine the mood, rhythm, and phrasing. But even a melody without lyrics needs a satisfying shape, with balancing phrases and resting points. Phrasing can be regular, like the example shown below, or irregular, but either way it should help the melody to feel well shaped.

▽ “My Bonnie Lies Over the Ocean”

The four lines of the verse translate into a four-phrase melody. The melodic shapes are similar, but their slight variations turn the implied harmonies around, leading back to the keynote.

Distinctive big leap of a 6th at the beginning of the melody.

My Bon - nie lies o - ver the o - cean, _____

Long note, making a clear ending to phrase 1.

Phrase 1

Phrase 2 starts like phrase 1, but takes a different direction in this measure.

At the end of phrase 2 the melody takes a questioning upward turn.

My Bon - nie lies o - ver the sea, _____

The rest gives singers a chance to breathe halfway through the verse.

Phrase 2

Phrase 3 repeats phrase 1.

My Bon-nie lies o - ver the o - cean, _____

Phrase 3

Phrase 4 starts differently, the first phrase to do so.

Phrase 4 and the whole verse ends on the keynote.

O bring back my Bon - nie to me. _____

Phrase 4